



Provide a Lost and Found Facility

D1.HSS.CL4.09

Trainee Manual



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Trainee Manual



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& hospitality

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Introduction to trainee manual

To the Trainee

Congratulations on joining this course. This Trainee Manual is one part of a 'toolbox' which is a resource provided to trainees, trainers and assessors to help you become competent in various areas of your work.

The 'toolbox' consists of three elements:

- A Trainee Manual for you to read and study at home or in class
- A Trainer Guide with Power Point slides to help your Trainer explain the content of the training material and provide class activities to help with practice
- An Assessment Manual which provides your Assessor with oral and written questions and other assessment tasks to establish whether or not you have achieved competency.

The first thing you may notice is that this training program and the information you find in the Trainee Manual seems different to the textbooks you have used previously. This is because the method of instruction and examination is different. The method used is called Competency based training (CBT) and Competency based assessment (CBA). CBT and CBA is the training and assessment system chosen by ASEAN (Association of South-East Asian Nations) to train people to work in the tourism and hospitality industry throughout all the ASEAN member states.

What is the CBT and CBA system and why has it been adopted by ASEAN?

CBT is a way of training that concentrates on what a worker can do or is required to do at work. The aim of the training is to enable trainees to perform tasks and duties at a standard expected by employers. CBT seeks to develop the skills, knowledge and attitudes (or recognise the ones the trainee already possesses) to achieve the required competency standard. ASEAN has adopted the CBT/CBA training system as it is able to produce the type of worker that industry is looking for and this therefore increases trainees chances of obtaining employment.

CBA involves collecting evidence and making a judgement of the extent to which a worker can perform his/her duties at the required competency standard. Where a trainee can already demonstrate a degree of competency, either due to prior training or work experience, a process of 'Recognition of Prior Learning' (RPL) is available to trainees to recognise this. Please speak to your trainer about RPL if you think this applies to you.

What is a competency standard?

Competency standards are descriptions of the skills and knowledge required to perform a task or activity at the level of a required standard.

242 competency standards for the tourism and hospitality industries throughout the ASEAN region have been developed to cover all the knowledge, skills and attitudes required to work in the following occupational areas:

- Housekeeping
- Food Production
- Food and Beverage Service

- Front Office
- Travel Agencies
- Tour Operations.

All of these competency standards are available for you to look at. In fact you will find a summary of each one at the beginning of each Trainee Manual under the heading 'Unit Descriptor'. The unit descriptor describes the content of the unit you will be studying in the Trainee Manual and provides a table of contents which are divided up into 'Elements' and 'Performance Criteria'. An element is a description of one aspect of what has to be achieved in the workplace. The 'Performance Criteria' below each element details the level of performance that needs to be demonstrated to be declared competent.

There are other components of the competency standard:

- *Unit Title*: statement about what is to be done in the workplace
- *Unit Number*: unique number identifying the particular competency
- *Nominal hours*: number of classroom or practical hours usually needed to complete the competency. We call them 'nominal' hours because they can vary e.g. sometimes it will take an individual less time to complete a unit of competency because he/she has prior knowledge or work experience in that area.

The final heading you will see before you start reading the Trainee Manual is the 'Assessment Matrix'. Competency based assessment requires trainees to be assessed in at least 2 – 3 different ways, one of which must be practical. This section outlines three ways assessment can be carried out and includes work projects, written questions and oral questions. The matrix is designed to show you which performance criteria will be assessed and how they will be assessed. Your trainer and/or assessor may also use other assessment methods including 'Observation Checklist' and 'Third Party Statement'. An observation checklist is a way of recording how you perform at work and a third party statement is a statement by a supervisor or employer about the degree of competence they believe you have achieved. This can be based on observing your workplace performance, inspecting your work or gaining feedback from fellow workers.

Your trainer and/or assessor may use other methods to assess you such as:

- Journals
- Oral presentations
- Role plays
- Log books
- Group projects
- Practical demonstrations.

Remember your trainer is there to help you succeed and become competent. Please feel free to ask him or her for more explanation of what you have just read and of what is expected from you and best wishes for your future studies and future career in tourism and hospitality.

Unit descriptor

Provide a Lost and Found Facility

This unit deals with the skills and knowledge required to Provide a Lost and Found Facility in a range of settings within the hotel and travel industries workplace context.

Unit Code:

D1.HSS.CL4.09

Nominal Hours:

15 hours

Element 1: Establish lost and found facility

Performance Criteria

- 1.1 Name properties that may have a lost and found facility
- 1.2 Identify appropriate location for lost and found facility
- 1.3 Develop in-house lost and found policies and procedures
- 1.4 Identify the legal requirements that apply to lost and found items
- 1.5 Communicate the location and function of the lost and found facility to guests and staff
- 1.6 Establish lost and found register

Element 2: Deal with lost and found items

Performance Criteria

- 2.1 Check items for safety and legality and take appropriate action
- 2.2 Record found items in lost and found register
- 2.3 Record items reported lost in lost and found register
- 2.4 Tag the found item
- 2.5 Store the found item appropriately
- 2.6 Notify owner, if known
- 2.7 Notify internal establishment staff to facilitate return of found item to owner

Element 3: Deal with claims for lost items

Performance Criteria

- 3.1 Assist claimant to identify lost property
- 3.2 Verify ownership of property claimed
- 3.3 Obtain identification from owner
- 3.4 Complete lost and found register
- 3.5 Assist claimants who contact the establishment from another country, or distant area, to claim lost items

Element 4: Deal with unclaimed items

Performance Criteria

- 4.1 Comply with establishment policies
- 4.2 Comply with legal obligations
- 4.3 Remove items from storage and complete lost and found register to record movement and disposal of items

Assessment matrix

Showing mapping of Performance Criteria against Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions

The Assessment Matrix indicates three of the most common assessment activities your Assessor may use to assess your understanding of the content of this manual and your performance - Work Projects, Written Questions and Oral Questions. It also indicates where you can find the subject content related to these assessment activities in the Trainee Manual (i.e. under which element or performance criteria). As explained in the Introduction, however, the assessors are free to choose which assessment activities are most suitable to best capture evidence of competency as they deem appropriate for individual students.

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 1: Establish lost and found facility				
1.1	Name properties that may have a lost and found facility	1.1	1	1
1.2	Identify appropriate location for lost and found facility	1.2	2	2
1.3	Develop in-house lost and found policies and procedures	1.2	3	3
1.4	Identify the legal requirements that apply to lost and found items	1.3	4, 5	4
1.5	Communicate the location and function of the lost and found facility to guests and staff	1.2	6	5
1.6	Establish lost and found register	1.2	7, 8	6
Element 2: Deal with lost and found items				
2.1	Check items for safety and legality and take appropriate action	2.2	9, 10	7
2.2	Record found items in lost and found register	2.2	11	8
2.3	Record items reported lost in lost and found register	2.1	12	9
2.4	Tag the found item	2.2	13	10
2.5	Store the found item appropriately	2.2	14, 15	11
2.6	Notify owner, if known	2.3	16	12
2.7	Notify internal establishment staff to facilitate return of found item to owner	2.3	17, 18	13

		Work Projects	Written Questions	Oral Questions
Element 3: Deal with claims for lost items				
3.1	Assist claimant to identify lost property	3.1	19	14
3.2	Verify ownership of property claimed	3.1	20	15
3.3	Obtain identification from owner	3.1	21	16
3.4	Complete lost and found register	3.1	22	17
3.5	Assist claimants who contact the establishment from another country, or distant area, to claim lost items	3.2	23	18
Element 4: Deal with unclaimed items				
4.1	Comply with establishment policies	4.1	24, 25	19
4.2	Comply with legal obligations	4.1	26	20
4.3	Remove items from storage and complete lost and found register to record movement and disposal of items	4.1	27	21

Glossary

Term	Explanation
AM	<i>Ante meridiem</i> meaning 'before midday'. 10:00AM is 10 o'clock in the morning
Bailment	A legal position where the ownership of goods is transferred from one person to another
CRS	Computerised Reservation System
Claimant	Person making a claim
Contraband	Any illegal item being used, possessed or smuggled
Fax	Facsimile
Floor Supervisor	A middle-level management person in the Housekeeping department with responsibility for one or more floors of guest rooms and facilities
Generic information	Information that is generally applicable
Gratuitous bailment	Bailment where a person finds and looks after lost property and there is no charge made for this
Grossly negligent	Serious failure to take care; deliberate disregard for duty of care obligations; to succeed in a 'grossly negligent' claim the evidence must show the person liable demonstrated more than 'ordinary' negligence
Hard copy materials	Printed or hand-written materials (as opposed to electronic/on screen versions)
ID	Identification
Lost and Found Register	A bound book containing details of all lost and found items enabling processing of lost and found items to be documented and tracked
PM	<i>Post meridiem</i> meaning 'after midday'. 10:00PM is 10 o'clock at night
POS	Point-Of-Sale

Term	Explanation
Photo ID	An item with photographic identification – such as a passport, driver's licence, identity card
SOP	Standard Operating Procedure – the required/approved way of doing something
Unsolicited	Without having been asked for

Element 1:

Establish lost and found facility

1.1 Name properties that may have a lost and found facility

Introduction

All guests expect venues to provide a formal, structured Lost and Found service.

The exact nature of each Lost and Found service can vary enormously, and the systems employed to support them can also vary widely.

This Section identifies properties offering such a service.

The Lost and Found facility

Lost Property Office

In most cases properties will not have a separate, stand-alone Lost and Found facility within the venue.

That is, there is rarely a 'Lost and Found' department, or a 'Lost and Found' office.

The term 'Lost and Found facility' is a generic term referring to the service and protocols provided by a venue to:

- Record lost and found items
- Store found items
- Facilitate the return of lost and found items to their rightful owners.

Properties with Lost and Found facility

There is no legal requirement for properties to have a Lost and Found facility but they are common in the following venues:

- Hotels
- Motels
- Commercial catering facilities
- Convention centres
- Casinos
- Clubs
- Restaurants
- Resorts
- Theme and amusement parks
- Tourist attractions



- Back-packer accommodation
- Bed and Breakfast establishments
- Dormitories
- Villas.

Lost and found items

Lost items

Lost items are items reported by guests/customers as having been lost – in most cases these items may have been left in a room, forgotten, or stolen.

Found items

Found items are items found by staff or guests/customers and handed in to venue staff.

It is possible one item can be, at the same time, both a lost and found item: It may have been identified as being lost by a guest while having been found and handed in by a staff member.



Classifications of found items

Properties often classify found items into one of three categories:

- Valuable items
- Non-valuable items
- Perishables items.

Examples of items in these classifications will be presented in Section 1.3.

Different requirements for dealing with each classification generally apply (see Sections 2.5 and 4.1).



1.2 Identify appropriate location for lost and found facility

Introduction

As already stated, most properties will not have a separate, stand-alone Lost and Found facility within the venue: that is, there is rarely a 'Lost and Found' department, or a 'Lost and Found' office.

This Section discusses the possible location of the Lost and Found facility within properties.

Location of Lost and Found facility

Accommodation venues

In hotels and other accommodation venues the Lost and Found facilities are generally incorporated within another area/department usually Housekeeping (Rooms Division).

The physical Lost and Found area will therefore usually be within the Executive Housekeeper's office, or – for larger 'found' items – within an allied stores area, such as the linen store/room.

This situation has evolved for two main reasons:

- Most 'found' items are found by housekeeping staff and come from rooms where in-house guests have departed.

Many items found are never claimed, perhaps because the guest does not know where they lost the item, or perhaps the item has been deliberately left behind because the guest does not want to take it with them.

Perhaps the value of the item is such they are not worried about it, or perhaps they simply believe it could not have been found, or handed in, so why bother

- The Housekeeper's office is a restricted access area and is not generally a high guest-traffic area: this enables increased security and safety for the items not available in some other areas such as, for instance, the baggage room.

It is also possible, depending on the size, layout and structure of the business; your Lost and Found facility/area may be located in/at:

- Manager's office
- Front office/reception
- Central stores area – in/adjacent to the Store Person's office.



Other property types

Properties that are not accommodation properties may have their Lost and Found facility located:

- At the ticket sales area/counter
- In a 'guest service' location – this is common at an amusement/theme park where the 'office' also provides a range of other services such as:
 - First aid
 - Baby change facilities
 - Cloakroom
 - Hire of equipment.

1.3 Develop in-house lost and found policies and procedures

Introduction

All properties offering formal Lost and Found facilities will have developed a set of policies and procedures to guide implementation of the service.

It is important you read and understand all relevant policies and procedures as they apply to your workplace.

This Section identifies and describes a variety of Lost and Found policies and procedures.

Location of Lost and Found policies and procedures

You should be able to access the Lost and Found policies and procedures in your workplace through one or more of the following:

- At Induction and Orientation – your Supervisor will advise you about what applies and where supporting information is located
- Staff manual – will contain a section titled/covering Lost and Found
- Venue intranet – larger businesses will feature an intranet facility which will enable access to all policies and procedures
- Workplace signs – including:
 - Information posters
 - Directional signage – pointing to the location of the Lost and Found facility
 - 'Lost and Found' signs.

Possible Lost and Found policies and procedures

Description of items

Businesses will provide information regarding a description/definition of items that will be kept and those that will be discarded (thrown out).

Properties often classify found items into one of three categories:

- Valuable items which include:
 - Cell phones
 - Cash over a certain amount – as nominated by the venue
 - Laptop computers – and accessories
 - Cameras
 - Watches
 - Jewellery
 - Car or house keys
 - Handbags and wallets
 - Travel documentation – passports, visas, tickets



- Business documentation – reports, notes, business papers, plans
- Personal items – credit cards, driver's licence
- Non-valuable items such as:
 - Magazines
 - Make-up/cosmetics
 - Old/damaged clothing
 - Stationery
- Perishables items:
 - Food
 - Drinks
 - Partly consumed items and unopened items.

Note: check with your Supervisor to determine what applies in your workplace.

Holding times

This will specify the length of time a property will retain an item before disposing of it.

See Section 4.1 for detail.

Disposal of items

This policy dictates what happens to found items if they are not claimed.

See Section 4.1 for detail.

Dangerous, illegal or suspicious items

To protect the property and staff, there will nearly always be directions about action to take to ensure correct treatment of dangerous, illegal or suspicious items.

More details on this are provided in Section 2.1.

Processing for found items

These protocols will explain the procedures for receiving, recording and storing/securing items handed in by staff and guests as 'found' items.

More detail on this will be provided in Section 2.2.

Policies and procedures will address:

- Staff with responsibility for processing items
- Documentation to be completed – such as Lost and Found Slip/Tag and Found Register/Lost and Found Register
- Location for storage of items
- Notifications – internally to other staff/departments and guests; externally to departed guests
- Disposal of items – when their storage period has elapsed and items have not been claimed.



Procedures for claiming items

These are the house requirements to be followed when a person makes a claim on a Lost and Found item.

Standard procedures require the person claiming the item to be able to describe the item or furnish reliable proof of ownership.

It is imperative items are never simply handed over to people making a claim without proof of ownership.

Relevant documentation must also be completed to track/record the return of the item.

Element 3 will provide more information on this topic.

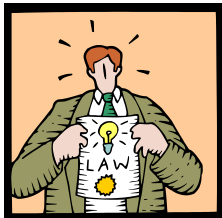
1.4 Identify the legal requirements that apply to lost and found items

Introduction

All properties have some form of legal obligation and responsibility when found items are handed in and stored for return to the person who lost them.

This Section highlights the issues to be aware of and emphasises the need for you to determine the legal requirements imposed on venues in this regard for your home country.

National laws



It is important to contact your local industry peak body and ask them about the legal implications in your country regarding lost and found items.

You may also talk to the local authorities/Police or discuss requirements with your Supervisor, or more senior/experienced workplace staff.

The information provided in these notes is generic in nature and based on industry best practice and ethical conduct.

On-the-job training

Your employer will also provide you with relevant advice and directions as part of your Induction and Orientation.

House policies, procedures and manuals will also reflect the legal requirements of your country.

Duty of Care

In this context (that is, where a property stores a found item with the intention of returning it to its rightful owner) 'duty of care' is a common law obligation requiring the hotel/staff to take action to protect the items against 'foreseeable harm'.

This means a hotel must take whatever action is necessary, given the circumstances applying at the time, to ensure the found item does not come to any harm.

(A similar duty of care requirement applies across the property to all guests, staff, and members of the public.)

In regard to lost property this duty of care applies to situations where:

- The hotel returns the item to the wrong person
- The hotel loses the item once it stored it for safe-keeping
- Damage occurred to the item as a result of an action/event within the property.

Breach of duty of care can give rise to the potential for a guest to sue the hotel for negligence (see 'Bailment' below).

Bailment

'Bailment' refers to the act of temporarily transferring custody/control of an item to someone else (or a business) – for example, if you leave your car in a car park, bailment has been created: you pay a fee to park and then come back at a later time to pick the car up. The same applies when you take clothes to be laundered/dry-cleaned – bailment again exists.

Gratuitous bailment

Where a hotel or business receives found items and stores them to return when a rightful claim is made on them, this too is bailment but of a different type to the car park and laundry/dry cleaner examples.



The bailment created when a hotel looks after lost property is called 'gratuitous bailment' and exists when no charge is made for the service of looking after the item, such as applies to 'lost and found' situations.

This means the hotel/venue:

- Cannot use the items for its own purposes
- Must take care of the item – the intention is the item should be returned in the same condition it was found in
- Need only prove the extent of the care provided for the item was 'low' – if they were sued
- Can be sued by the person who lost the item if the item is returned in a damaged condition (or has been lost by the property) if – **and only if** – the person who lost the item can prove the hotel was '**grossly**' negligent.

In general terms, bailment provides the hotel must return the found item to its rightful owner in the same condition it was in when it was lost.

Concept of receiving stolen property

It is possible someone taking possession of an item for processing as 'found' property may be charged with 'receiving stolen property' if:

- The items were, in fact, stolen
- The person knew, or ought reasonable be aware, they were stolen
- The person who received the items deliberately intended to receive the items and have them under their control.

Where the person had no intent to receive the stolen goods, did not know they were stolen or the goods were not, in fact, stolen it is highly unlikely a prosecution would be commenced or succeed.

The point to raising awareness about the potential for receiving stolen goods is to refuse to accept any items where you believe there is the possibility they may be stolen.

If in doubt about a situation of this nature, contact your Supervisor/Manager for advice.

1.5 Communicate the location and function of the lost and found facility to guests and staff

Introduction

From time-to-time there can be a need to advise guests/customers about the location of the Lost and Found area in your workplace and to explain to them how to hand in or claim an item.

This Section identifies methods to communicate with people in this regard and identifies skills to be applied.

Advising guests/customers



Where formal Lost and Found services are available, the venue will seek to inform guests/customers about them.

Communication regarding the Lost and Found facility should take place to optimise its use both by staff and guests, and ensure lost items are returned to their owners.

This communication can occur verbally, in print, or via signage.

Verbally

Staff should never *offer* Lost and Found advice to guests/customers.

Information should only be provided when:

- Specifically asked a question – perhaps because the person has an item to hand in or they have lost something
- There is a situation where the advice is appropriate – for example, a person tells you they cannot find their watch but are not certain (at this stage) it is actually 'lost'
- One guest/customer advises you someone else in the venue has lost or found an item.

Advising people verbally is an excellent option for sharing information as it allows you to:

- Verify people have understood what you have told them
- Follow-up the verbal advice with other help – such as escorting them to the Lost and Found service area.

See also 'Communication skills' (below).

Printed materials

Most properties will have the following hard-copy options as ways of advising guests/customers about Lost and Found:

- Guest account – a line or two is commonly included on the guest account advising them of how to contact Lost and Found after their departure if there is a need to do so

- Guest room compendium – there is usually a section in the in-room compendium advising guests:
 - The venue has a Lost and Found facility
 - Where it is
 - How to contact it.

Attention should be paid to providing these materials in different languages to match customer/guest profiles.

Other options

On-screen

Depending on the property and the level of in-room facilities, Lost and Found information may be provided:

- Through the information facility on the television in the guest room
- Via a touch screen information unit in the lobby/foyer.

Signage



In some cases there may be signage – usually in the reception-foyer area – indicating the location of the Lost and Found facility.

As with any printed form these signs may be required to be written in a variety of languages.

Obtaining updated Lost and Found information

Staff can obtain updated information about internal Lost and Found procedures:

- At regular (weekly, fortnightly) staff meetings
- At daily staff briefings and de-briefings – before work
- By reading the Communications Book – used by management in some venues to communicate important information to staff
- By regular reading of intranet files – policies, procedures, updates, alerts
- By reading all communications issued by management – such as emails, memos and posters on the staff information board in the tea room, change room, recreation room
- Through mandatory on-the-job training sessions.

Communication skills

When communicating with guests/customers about Lost and Found facilities and protocols the following interpersonal and communication skills should be applied:

- Demonstrate a willingness to help/communicate – never treat these situations as an imposition
- Show respect for the person – and concern for their situation/loss
- Use appropriate verbal language – as appropriate to the person's age and race
- Use non-verbal communication to support the spoken word and other action taken – ensure body language matches the verbal language

- Be prepared to accompany the person to the Lost and Found area – as opposed to simply providing verbal or other directions/instructions
- Use sign language – where there is a communication problem caused by language differences: Point
- Speak at an appropriate pace and volume – do not yell, do not whisper
- Use person's name where it is known or use 'Sir' or 'Madam'
- Check your advice/information has been understood – ask if the person has understood or needs more information, a different explanation or another person to explain things
- Thank anyone who wants to hand a found item in – always thank people for their help, honesty and cooperation.

1.6 Establish lost and found register

Introduction

All properties offering a Lost and Found facility will feature a Lost and Found register.

Properties may purchase a Lost and Found Register from a hospitality supplier or prepare their own using the workplace computer.

This Section identifies the contents and role of this Register.

The Lost and Found Register

Combined Lost and Found Register

The Lost and Found Register is a bound book – that is, it is not loose-leaf.

The book is bound so pages cannot easily be removed, and if they are removed it is easy to see where they have been taken from.

Pages in the register are usually sequentially numbered pages.

Found items may be listed at the front of the register and reports regarding lost items may be recorded at the rear of the book.

The Register records three primary types of information:

- All appropriate items found on the premises by staff and/or customers and guests
- Details of all items reported as lost by customers/guests
- Actions taken in relation to lost and found items – including:
 - Efforts to find lost items – action taken by staff/the property in response to reports from guests/customers they have lost an item
 - Storage of found items – identifying where items have been stored so they can be easily retrieved when a claim is made
 - Details of the return of an item to its owner – identifying the owner and evidence obtain identifying the claimant as the rightful owner
 - Details of disposal of found items – to prove/demonstrate what happened to unclaimed items and when this took place.

Found items

For 'found items' the register will usually provide space to record:

- Item number (optional) – some properties allocate every found item a number to assist with tracking
- Date/time – the item was found
- Description of item – sufficiently detailed to distinguish it from other similar items
- Finder – name and contact details of person who found it
- Location found – name of room/area where the item was found
- Name of owner/room occupant – where known
- Receipt number – some venues will issue a receipt to the finder whenever a found item is handed in: this helps maintain accountability and reduced chance of staff stealing items
- Action taken – to find the owner (where appropriate)
- Final disposal of the item such as:
 - 'Returned to Owner'
 - 'Discarded'
 - 'Donated to XYZ'
- Signature of claimant – where item was returned to owner, including details of evidence presented by the claimant to prove they were the owner, such as:
 - Driver's licence number
 - Passport number
 - Reference to photocopied material filed for future reference.

Lost items

For items reported as lost the following details need to be recorded:

- Date/time – the lost report was made
- Description of item – in sufficient detail to allow the item to be identified
- Value of the item (optional) – indicating how much the item is worth
- Location where item was lost – if known
- Name of person who has lost the item
- Contact details – of person who has lost the item
- Action taken – to find the lost item.

Sample Lost and Found Register

The 'found' items section of the Register

The Lost and Found Register may have the following pages at the front of the book usually in Landscape format.

Item No.	Date/Time Found	Location Found	Description & Value	Name of Finder	Tag or Receipt No.	Action Taken	Disposal or Return	Sign. In	Sign. Out

Many variations on the above example are present within the industry at different properties

The 'lost' items section of the Register

The Lost and Found Register may have the following pages at the rear of the Register usually in Landscape format.

Date/Time Lost	Location Lost	Description & Value	Name of Contact	Action Taken	Returned – Date & Details of Proof of Ownership	Signature of Claimant

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 1.1 Prepare and submit a list of at least ten (10) venues or establishments in your local area/region providing a Lost and Found facility.
- 1.2 For your workplace – or a nominated alternative venue – prepare and present a submission:
 - Identifying the physical location of the Lost and Found facility within the business
 - Listing and describing the policies and procedures applying to the Lost and Found facility – with special attention to holding/storage periods for different classifications of items
 - Explaining how the business communicates the location and function of the Lost and Found facility to its guests/patrons
 - Contains a sample page (reproduction or copy) of the 'Lost' items and 'Found' items pages of the Lost and Found Register for the property.
- 1.3 For the business used as the basis for the response to Work Project 1.2 (immediately above) prepare and submit a comprehensive report identifying all the legal requirements applicable to lost and found items at the venue.

Note: the intention of this Work Project is for students to research and present the legal requirements applying to lost and found items in their country.

Summary

Establish lost and found facility

When establishing a Lost and Found facility:

- Realise the aims of this facility are to record lost and found items, and to store and return found items to their rightful owners
- Most properties and venues will benefit from establishing such a facility
- Be prepared for a wide range of items to be lost and found items
- Select an appropriate area/location for the facility that is safe, secure and not open to the public
- Develop a series of appropriate policies, procedures and protocols to support the operation of the facility aimed at effectively dealing with valuable, non-valuable and perishable items
- Create protocols for dealing with dangerous, suspicious or illegal lost and found items
- Ensure the lost and found system enables compliance with 'Duty of Care' and 'Bailment' requirements
- Advise guests/customers regarding the location and function of the Lost and Found facility
- Use appropriate communication skills when dealing with people in relation to lost and found items
- Establish a Lost and Found Register and Lost and Found tags/slips to facilitate the recording of lost and found items.

Element 2: Deal with lost and found items

2.1 Check items for safety and legality and take appropriate action

Introduction

All items handed in as 'found' items must be checked to ensure they are safe and appropriate to accept into storage.

This Section identifies items requiring special attention and the action to take when dealing with these items.



Checking items

It is important all items submitted to Lost and Found must be checked to ensure they are not dangerous, suspicious or illegal.

Checking involves:

- Inspecting/looking at the item – to look for danger signs such as:
 - Sharp/jagged edges
 - Broken glass
 - Leaks
 - A physical item that by its very nature gives rise to concern
- Using the other senses – to detect any smells or sounds causing concern
- Making sure, to the best extent possible the item is safe and secure for handling and storage
- Using common sense – to determine the nature and safety of the item.

Dangerous, suspicious or illegal items

Most properties will provide directions on how staff should deal with found items deemed to be dangerous, suspicious or illegal.

Dangerous or illegal items

If you are unsure about whether or not something is dangerous, suspicious or illegal – **always** err on the side of caution and never be afraid of getting your Supervisor involved.

Dangerous or illegal goods include:

- Drugs
- Weapons

- Contraband
- Explosives.

If in doubt about the nature of something handed in – seek assistance: remember, **always** err on the side of caution.

If a parcel of white powder has been handed in – assume it is drugs.

In addition, items may not themselves be dangerous, but the condition/state they are in may render them dangerous: an electrical appliance may be safe, but one that has exposed cords is dangerous; a tin of ‘something’ may be safe, but if it is leaking it has the potential to be unsafe; a knife may not in itself be dangerous but the sharpness of the blade together with the sharpness of its point may mean it can be described as dangerous.

Suspicious items

Any items handed in must also be checked to ensure they are not suspicious in nature.

Certainly, today, many establishments are more aware of the possibility of terrorist activity than ever before. This means staff should be aware of any packages left lying around, unattended or which are in a place they should not be, and hence are a cause for suspicion.

Again, err on the side of caution, and never be afraid of getting a Supervisor/manager involved in the situation.

Where a suspicious package is identified, the appropriate response is:

- Do not touch it
- Phone the Police and report the finding – stay on the line until told to hang up: answer questions to the best of your ability
- Leave the package in the place/situation where it was discovered
- Evacuate people from the immediate area – you may elect to evacuate people from a wider area depending on the nature of what it is you have found: follow the directions in your Emergency Management/Evacuation Plan
- Turn off anything likely to trigger an explosion, such as mobile phones
- Wait for the authorities to arrive – and deal with the item.

What is the definition of a ‘suspicious package’?

There is no definition of a suspicious package.

Many items that do not look suspicious have in fact concealed a device that has exploded.

Certainly there are indications a package may conceal a device – and experts know what to look for.

The problem, however, is that if you examine a package and believe it has no tell-tale signs it is, say, a bomb, you may then move it and by so doing, detonate it.

It is for this reason these notes have deliberately omitted information about what signs to look for – treat **every** suspicious package with the utmost care and respect: follow the advice given above.



When the authorities have been notified, they will attend and assist with evacuation as well as determining which other services should be called in to deal with the item.

While you do not want to over-react to suspicious package situations, it is important to make the decision relatively quickly about whether or not 'a situation' exists: commonly individuals are reluctant to contact authorities in case there is not a problem and they think they will then be made to look foolish – you must overcome this thought.

It really is a case of being 'better safe than sorry'.

Naturally, house policies regarding this potential situation should be read and adhered to: where you are uncertain about any aspects of the relevant house policies or procedures in this area, make sure you clarify them with the appropriate person before a real need to do so arises.

Generic information on handling practices and protocols

Once items submitted as found items have been checked for safety and legality, they may be accepted and signed-in to the Lost and Found facility using the appropriate Register.

Standard practices and protocols for handling the items include:

- Treating/handling items with respect and care – treat them as if they were your own personal and prized possessions
- Packaging items to protect them from damage – where appropriate such as when dealing with fragile items or items likely to be easily scratched/marked
- Securing the items – placing them into locations to ensure they are not stolen or lost
- Leaving items alone until they are claimed or need to be disposed of – this highlights 'found' items cannot be used by staff or the property.

2.2 Record found items in lost and found register

Introduction

A standard requirement when a 'found' item is handed in is for it to be entered into the Lost and Found Register.

This Section identifies the requirements for entering found items into this Register.



Recording required information for a 'found' item

There is no mandatory *sequence* of tasks when recording required details into the Lost and Found Register but the following order is an effective model.

In practice, there is often a need to return to a previous entry to add more detail (or alter information) based on subsequent facts provided by the person handing the item in.

When making entries into the Register take time to ensure:

- Your writing is legible – others will have to read and interpret what you write
- Information is correct – double-check the entries to ensure they are accurate
- Information is comprehensive – it is worth taking an extra minute to record all/more detail.

When all necessary details have been recorded in the Register (for both 'lost' and 'found' items) they should be verified with the person concerned (for example the staff member/person handing in a found item or the individual reporting a lost item).

Reading the details back is the best way to achieve this.

Identifying finder



This requirement involves identifying the person who found the item.

This is usually the name of a staff member of guest who founded/handed in the item – you should record their full name.

There is no need to capture their date of birth but it is useful to record a contact for them – this may be a telephone number or address for a guest/member of the public or (for staff) their extension number.

Be aware a guest **is not obliged** to provide their name, address or contact phone number when handing in a 'found' item if they do not want to do so: you cannot force or demand they do so.

Note: in some cases a staff member may be handing the 'found' item in but the item may have been found by a guest and given/passed on to the staff member.

Identifying location

For all items entered into the Register it should be standard to:

- Identify the place the item was found – such as:
 - Room 342
 - Grand Dining Room
 - Outside
- Identify the location in the place – such as:
 - On the double bed
 - Under Table 5 near the flower display
 - Near the kiosk by the swimming pool.

Identifying date and time

All items should be recorded to indicate:

- Date – the item was found
- Day of the week – to confirm the date
- Time – using the 24-hour clock, or AM/PM designation.

24-Hour clock

Many properties use the 24-hour clock to record/state times.

This option is based on the way the military refers to time.



It acknowledges there are 24 hours in a day and the system is said to remove the potential for confusion about times that can occur when using the AM/PM system (see immediately below).

In the 24-hour clock method:

- 00.00 = midnight
- 01.00 = 1 o'clock in the morning
- 06.00 = 6 o'clock in the morning
- 12.00 = midday/noon
- 15.00 – 3 o'clock in the afternoon
- 19.00 = 7 o'clock in the evening
- 23.00 = 11 o'clock in the evening
- 10.15 = quarter past 10 in the morning
- 16.25 = twenty-five minutes past 4 in the afternoon
- 22.45 = 10:45PM/quarter to eleven at night.

AM/PM

AM

AM is a Latin term (*ante meridiem*) meaning 'before midday'.

2:00AM is 2 o'clock in the morning.

9:00AM is 9 o'clock in the morning.

11:15AM is a quarter past eleven/15 minutes after 11 in the morning.

PM

PM is a Latin term (*post meridiem*) meaning 'post midday'.

4:00PM is 4 o'clock in the afternoon.

6:00PM is 6 o'clock in the evening.

10:30PM is a half past ten at night.

Identifying the item



Any item handed in to Lost and Found must have its description recorded, together with any other relevant details, on the Lost and Found slip (or 'tag') and in the register.

Details about the item itself must be recorded to assist in identification of the item when it needs to be retrieved from storage – this is important because many items will be stored somewhere separate from where the Lost and Found Register is kept and is necessary to help whoever is trying to assist a guest making a claim.

While there is a common sense limit about the amount of detail and description, it needs to be sufficient to accurately and quickly identify the object in question.

Details must also be sufficient and accurate enough to help differentiate between similar products handed in.

Description details may include, but are obviously not limited to:

- General description of item – such as 'gent's watch', 'briefcase', bottle of scotch
- Brand name, model name/style, and serial number where possible
- Distinguishing features/marks – cuts, scratches, dents, sticky tape, ribbon on suitcase handles or anything else to distinguish it from other similar items
- Size, colour, shape, material out of which it is made – it is possible not all of these may apply in all cases but it can be useful to record the case is 'brown leather', the drinking glasses are 'stemmed crystal', or the painting is a 'framed rectangular' one.

For example, if a bottle of spirits was handed in you would record type of spirit, brand, bottle size, whether bottle was opened/how full it was

- Other information may include, as appropriate:
 - It was found, for example, in a Sony bag shopping bag
 - The item was still in its original packaging/wrapper
 - It was found in an old cardboard box.

Allocating item an identifying number

Some properties (but not all) will allocate a number to every item handed in as a 'found item'.

Generally items are sequentially numbered – that is, the item handed in after Item 34 will be item 35.

This number will:

- Entered under the appropriate heading/column in the register – such as Item Number or Serial Number
- Be the same number appearing on the Lost and Found Slip/Lost and Found Tag attached to the item when it is placed into storage – see more on this in Section 2.4.



Signing the item in

Where this is a requirement, the person taking the details of the 'found item' and receiving the item into the Lost and Found facility must sign the Register to indicate:

- The name of the person processing the found item – so others know who to contact/speak to if they have a query
- The details written in the Register and true and correct – the need for a signature increases accountability
- The item has been received – and is now the responsibility of the property in relation to bailment and duty of care obligations.

2.3 Record items reported lost in lost and found register

Introduction



When a guest/customer reports they have lost an item, the details of this loss must be recorded in much the same way as details of a 'found' item are recorded.

This Section identified the information needing to be obtained when dealing with a lost property report.

Interpersonal skills

When dealing with customers or guests who are reporting a lost item the first necessity is to appreciate the item being reported as lost can have immense value to the customer/guest that is not immediately or obviously understood by others/you.

To many people the problem associated with the loss of an item is not its monetary worth but its intrinsic value in terms of sentimental value, the work and effort that has gone into a missing business report in the lost briefcase or the interruption and inconvenience to their normal life that not having their wallet/purse causes.

The wallet might only be worth only a small amount but the annoyance and inconvenience lies in having to notify all the relevant authorities and businesses about the credit cards, driver's licence, membership cards and other items needing to be replaced.

Not to mention the problems the loss of cash may cause in the immediate short-term.

This means you have to try and put yourself in the other person's shoes in order to appreciate their loss and the accompanying anxiety.

This appreciation and acknowledgement must be reflected in the way these people are dealt with and key factors are:

- Acknowledging not only their loss but *the way they are feeling* about their loss – and the inconvenience the loss is causing
- Being professional in the way you record details of their lost item – this involves showing interest, asking questions to assist in identifying the item and in (perhaps) locating the item
- It includes not rushing the customer and thus giving them the impression you want to get this over with as quickly as possible
- You must take time and show concern – it is important the customer/guest feels you/the property will take action to find the item and return it
- Obtaining their contact details – so you can contact them if the item is found
- Giving them your contact details – this may be a business card from the property with your name and numbers on it
- Advising them about the action you intend to take to recover their lost property – such as searching their room, speaking to all staff on that floor, viewing the security tape for the area, checking the Lost and Found register/storage area

- Explaining any charges that may apply to forwarding the item to them – as and when the item is found.

Three important things to remember when communicating with people who have lost items and are reporting their loss are:

- Show sensitivity
- Demonstrate interest and involvement
- Prove you are doing something to try to locate the item.

Identifying person who lost the item

It is always necessary to capture the name of the person who has lost the item being reported as lost.

Full name is required, but other details (such as date of birth) are not.

In a significant number of cases the person reporting the lost item is not the owner – for example the person making the report may be a family member, or a friend – especially where the guest has departed overseas/internationally.

You must never return/release a 'found' item to anyone other than the owner unless there is documentation from the owner authorising return/release to a third party.

If in doubt, talk to your Supervisor.



Identifying 'lost' location

The 'lost location' is the place the guest/customer:

- Knows they last had the item – that is, they are 100% sure/certain
- Believes they last had the item – this is their 'best guess' about where they lost or misplaced the item.

The more detail and accuracy the guest/customer can provide the better. This information will provide the focus for the initial search by property staff for the lost item.

In many cases, an item is recovered/found in area not identified by the customer/guest – meaning many people forget where they last had the item.

In truth, many/most 'lost items' are forgotten rather than actually lost.

Identifying date and time

Guest/customers are often unsure about when they lost an item especially if they are unsure about where they lost it.

Try to capture the 'best guess' the person can provide.

The greater the time difference between the report and the act of losing the item, the less of a chance there is the item will be found.

It is important to record the date/time as this can assist the property if they are sued by the owner of the lost item as the timeframe can be influential in determining whether liability exists, and/or the extent of the liability.

Describing item

The same attention to describing a 'lost item' must be applied when recording a 'lost item'. Please refer/re-read Section 2.2 (above) for details.

Remember:

- The intention is to allow those looking for the lost item to be able to readily identify the item if they find it, and differentiate it from similar items
- Most properties require an estimation of the value of the item to be supplied – if possible, a receipt for the purchase of the item should be obtained and photocopied
- There will commonly be a need to change the description while details are being captured as the person reporting the loss offers more/different information.

Note

Be prepared for the person who has lost an item **not** to be able to give an accurate description of the item.

This may sound strange – and often appear suspicious – but it is a fact of life many people cannot tell you the make, colour, brand (or even detailed contents) of a bag/suitcase they use every day/regularly.

Obtaining contact details

It is important to capture contact details of the person making the report, or the contact details of the owner of the item, as appropriate to the individual situation – as mentioned, not all people reporting the loss are the owners of the missing item.

Contact details may need to be quite extensive especially if the person has left the property/area.

Details may include:

- Cell phone number
- Work telephone number
- Home telephone number
- Email address
- Fax number
- Street address of home/business
- Post office box address.



2.4 Tag the found item

Introduction

Once a found item has been recorded in the Lost and Found register, the item will be tagged and stored.

This Section identifies activities involved in this step and presents a sample Lost property Slip/Tag.

Tagging the item

Tagging an item involves completing a Lost and Found Tag/Slip and attaching it to the found item.

Methods for attaching the tag/slip to the item will depend on the item but common options are:

- Adhesive tape
- String
- Elastic/rubber bands.



Every tag/slip will have a unique number – the number on the tag/slip must match the tag/slip number for the item, as written in the Lost and Found Register.

All other details on the tag/slip must also align with the information recorded in the Register.

Completing and attaching the tag to the item must occur as part of the processing process for a 'found' item – it must not be left till a later time: tagging must occur as soon as the Register is finalised for the item, or as part of the process of filling in the Register.

Sample Lost Property Tag/Slip

As with the Lost and Found Register, there are many different formats for these slips/tags.

Tags can contain more, less or different information to what is presented below.

The tags/slips are commonly produced by each property to meet its individual needs, but standard commercially-prepared tags are available.

WALSH HOTELS INTERNATIONAL**Found Item Tag**

Item/tag Number: _____

Date found: _____

Date stored: _____

Description of item:

Where found (inc. room # as appropriate):

Finder: _____

Special instructions/advice:

DISPOSAL

Returned to Owner:

Date: _____ Name of Owner: _____

Disposed of:

Date: _____ How disposed of: _____

Name of person disposing of item: _____

Lost and Found Register updated: Yes/No.

2.5 Store the found item appropriately

Introduction

Following tagging of found items, items must be stored.

This Section describes the considerations and options relating to the safe-keeping of found items.

Storing options



You will recall there is rarely a dedicated Lost and Found area doing nothing else but handling lost and found items and queries.

As already indicated the Housekeeping department and associated areas (laundry, linen room) as well as the stores areas and managers' offices can be the Lost and Found area.

Within these areas/locations the physical units used to store items can include:

- Storing perishable food under refrigeration – if a decision has been made to hold the food for 24 – 48 hours
- Placing valuable items into secure storage – such as keeping them:
 - In a locked room – designated shelves in a room/cupboard may be allocated to 'lost property'
 - In a locked drawer or cupboard – designated cabinets, cupboards or drawers may be allocated specifically for the storage of found items
 - In a safe
- Storing non-valuable items in a range places including:
 - General-purpose cupboards
 - Shelves used for other stock/purposes
 - On the floor in store rooms and offices
 - Same locations as for valuable items.

Storing items

Regardless of what method/facilities are used to store found items the prime requirements are:

- They can be recovered accurately and quickly – when a query or claim is made
- They are stored safely – to protect them from damage and theft
- There is limited access to the area or items – from staff and customers/guests.

This means that Lost and Found items, especially the valuable ones, are securely stored in a locked environment, with limited and accountable access.

There is no set legal requirement for the nature of the actual Lost and Found area – some properties conduct 'temporary' facilities (in situations, say, when they have an unusually large number of guests at an event, function or seminar/conference).

It must always be remembered there is little point implementing a Lost and Found facility if it does not have a suitable storage phase: in addition it is highly embarrassing to respond to a phone call from a guest telling them their lost article has been found only to find you cannot locate it – and the guest is on their way to pick it up.

Points to remember about storing found items

All venues will have their own requirements relating to the storage of found items.

The following notes build on notes presented in Section 1.3.

Perishable food found in guest rooms



Where perishable foods are found, two options are commonly available.

The first option is staff – and this is usually housekeeping staff/Room Attendants – have discretionary powers to deal with any perishable food they find.

This food may include leftover takeaway foods, a few biscuits in an open packet, or a couple of slices of cheese, a tomato and some slices of bread.

Using their discretion, staff may elect – if the room is a departing room – to throw out such items.

Naturally the food would be left there if the room was a 'stay' room.

The second option is the Standard Operating Procedure requires all staff to take all found perishable food to the Executive Housekeeper's Office, and to allow them to make the decision.

Liquor/Beverages

Commonly, any *unopened* bottle of liquor – spirits, wine, beer or soft drink else is logged in the standard way, and the liquor then forwarded (perhaps) to the central liquor store: if the bottle is not claimed the venue may use/dispense/sell it.

Unopened bottles of liquor are usually treated as 'valuable' items.

Opened bottles of liquor may be stored in the normal Lost and Found store, or can be forwarded to another department.

It is useful to remember what is actually inside a bottle of open beverage could be anything! What is on the label may not be what is in the bottle, so it is not advisable to take a sip or use it.

You could be in for a very unpleasant surprise.

Opened bottles of soft drink found in a departing room are usually disposed of, as per perishable food.



Other items

It is worth checking house rules as they apply in your workplace regarding the following:

- Newspapers and magazines – in a 'stay' room they are left in the room unless the guest has placed them in the waste paper basket in the room: in a 'departing' room, they are usually thrown out
- Books/novels – if a book or novel is found in a departing room, they are usually handed in and treated as a found item
- Cash – check to see if your venue has a special rule about cash. Does all cash found in a 'departing' guest room have to be handed in? If you found *one only* of the smallest denomination coins, do you have to hand that in? Or, is there some cut-off/cut-in point such that only amounts over a set figure have to be handed in?

2.6 Notify owner, if known

Introduction

The intention of having a Lost and Found facility is to re-unite property with legitimate owners.

This Section highlights certain issues to be aware of and sensitive to, and identifies potential activities involved in advising owners you have recovered/found their lost property.



Need to be sensitive

Most properties will contact an owner and forward found 'valuable' items to them if the venue/staff know who they are.

Discretion however must be exercised about the nature of the item involved.

Where the item is of a 'sensitive' nature, contact will usually not be made with a known owner and the item will not be sent/forwarded unsolicited (that is, unless specifically requested).

'Sensitive' items are generally of a sexual nature (lingerie or toys).

Similarly, items of clothing are usually not sent unsolicited: this applies to clothing from either gender and regardless of the nature of the item.

Staff also need to be aware of and sensitive to the habits/patterns of guests which can also give rise to the need for sensitivity: for example, a guest who attends the property on a regular basis with different partners should give rise to the need to be sensitive to advising them about any found items in their rooms.

In all cases where sensitivity is required, no contact is made with the guest/customer – the found item is simply logged and stored: if the guest wants to make an enquiry as to whether or not it has been found, or make a claim for it, the venue will believe the responsibility rests with the guest.

Notifying known owners

Accepting there is a need for sensitivity, tact and discretion in some cases, the procedure in most cases (subject to individual house policy requirements) will be to contact the known adviser and advise them an item of theirs has been found.

Points to note include:

- The person who has lost the item may not know at this point they have lost the item – for example, many wallets are returned before the owner realises they have lost them, so be prepared for their surprise
- You are not doing the person a favour by returning the item/notifying them the item has been found – this is all part of the service provided by the venue and incorporated into the room rate/prices they pay.

Identifying the owner

Items found in rooms

If an item is found in a departed guest room, you should contact front office to obtain the details of the last occupier.

These details will be recorded on Guest History and/or their Registration Card/Form.

Items found in a dining area

Contact the dining area to determine if they have captured a contact number as part of the reservation process for a table.

Look inside the item

If the found item is a wallet, purse, bag, suitcase, diary, or folder it is acceptable – and often very effective – to look inside the article to determine if the owner's name can be found.

Sometimes the owner's name and contact details can be identified.

If only the name can be discovered, this should be run through the CRS/internal system to see if a match with a current/past guest can be made which will/may lead to obtaining contact details.

Action to take

Immediate/short-term action

Standard procedure (subject to organisational policies) may be to, as soon as possible/immediately:

- Contact the occupier of the room first – by internal telephone or internal/in-room messaging system where the guest is still resident in the property
- Determine if they want the item returned
- Agree on arrangements for the return of the item, where applicable.

Where the owner has departed the venue contact is commonly made:

- Using the person's cell phone number as opposed to ringing their 'home' or 'business' number – this is done to maintain the guest's privacy and in order to be tactful and avoid involving other people.

Making contact with the owner via email is often not recommended/used as it provides a record/possible hard copy of the situation which the guest/owner may not want or appreciate.

Likewise, making contact via standard mail is also not preferred as it can take 'too long' as well as (again) providing a hard copy of the situation.

Follow-up action for returning lost items

Properties are typically prepared to act on the owner's behalf to forward found items to them if they want the items returned.

Options for return of the item usually include:

- Physically taking the item to the guest – in their room or wherever in the venue they happen to be at the time
- Sending the item through the mail
- Using a courier to deliver the item
- Arrangements for the owner (or an authorised/nominated person) to collect the item.

In most cases the venue seeks to recover costs involved in sending the article to its owner, and this must be clearly stated to the person concerned. The guest/owner should also be asked if they want the item returned using a premium mail/delivery system and/or if they want the item insured.

Costs are usually limited to the specific postage or courier costs plus applicable insurance and other delivery charges – charges are not commonly made for the time and trouble taken by the venue for returning the item.

A forwarding address must be obtained (this may not be the person's residential address as they could be on an extended holiday, in which case the address could be another hotel elsewhere in the country or overseas), and the method of delivery agreed upon.

When an item is sent via mail/courier it is traditional to send an accompanying letter with it thanking the guest and including a 'With Compliments' card/note.

It may also be a requirement that a copy of all correspondence sent is recorded in an appropriate Correspondence Out file.

The Lost and Found Register must be updated to reflect return of the item.



2.7 Notify internal establishment staff to facilitate return of found item to owner

Introduction

The job of physically returning a found item to a guest can be the responsibility of a variety of workers.

This Section identifies who may have responsibility and presents the communication options commonly used to advise staff in relation to facilitating the return of the item.

Relevant staff

Staff responsible for returning found items to guests/customers will depend on:

- The type of establishment where the item was found
- The size of the operation
- The structure of the business and the different roles within it
- Where the item was found
- Whether the item is to be returned to a guest/customer who is on the premises
- Whether the item needs to be forwarded locally, nationally or internationally
- Special arrangements/requests made by the owner – for example, insisting the item is air-freighted to them.

Staff with this responsibility can therefore range from management/owner-level through to basic operational staff, and include:

- Housekeeping staff – Floor Supervisors are commonly involved in this task
- Concierge – the 'Information Desk' at the venue must always be notified about items that have been found in a hotel as many guests make this desk their first point of contact/enquiry
- Porters
- Security staff
- General assistants
- Sales and service staff
- Reception/front office staff.

Points to note

When processing the return of a found item to a guest/customer it is vital to:

- Work quickly – once the guest/customer has been advised their item has been found they will be expecting prompt service to return it
- Double-check the correct item is being sent/forwarded – read the tag/slip, and check this against the Lost and Found Register



- Take care – treat/handle the item with respect and care when wrapping/packaging it for delivery/sending
- Update the Lost and Found Register – to reflect what has occurred in relation to disposal/return of the item
- Keep receipts – relating to sending/delivery of the item to support charges levied on the owner, and as proof the item was sent, when it was sent and how it was sent
- Ensure the maintenance of guest privacy is maintained – in relation to the item itself, their contact details and other personal information.

Communication options

Staff who are to be given responsibility for returning a found item to a guest/customer will often be the staff member who contacted the owner to make enquiries about the item's return.

This is common because:

- It provides continuity in the process – and allocates final action to the person who made the arrangements with the customer/guest for that action
- It saves one person having to tell another person what is required – saving time and the possibility of error creeping into the process.



Where another staff member will take responsibility for the return of an item, they can be informed about requirements/arrangements:

- Face-to-face on a one-on-one basis – the best option as it allows checking to ensure the person knows and understands what is required, and allows clarification of issues/requirements
- Over the phone – the second best option
- Via email – containing all relevant details and directions
- Verbally at a staff briefing.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 2.1 Complete and submit a sample page from the Lost and Found Register at the venue where you work (or another nominated venue) recording an item reported as lost by a guest/patron.

The report may be a real-life report or a simulated report.

The submitted page must:

- Be professionally completed
- Contain comprehensive and clear details of the lost item
- Identify date, time and location, as appropriate
- Show the name of the person who lost the item together with their contact details.

- 2.2. Submit written and/or other evidence (such as video or photographs) to demonstrate/prove you have:

- Entered correct and comprehensive details recording a 'found' item in a venue Lost and Found Register ensuring all required columns of the register have been completed
- Checked the 'found' item to ensure it is safe and legal
- Tagged the item for storage
- Stored the item appropriately.
- The submission may be based on a real-life situation or a simulated event.

- 2.3. A guest who is staying in your workplace has lost their wallet and it has just been handed in to you. It was found by a waiter under a table in the dining area. The guest appears unaware they have lost the wallet.

Prepare and present a submission outlining:

- How you might identify the owner of the wallet
- How you will determine if the owner is a house guest
- How you will determine the room number they are staying in
- How you might contact the guest to advise them their wallet has been found
- Other staff in the venue you might notify regarding the found wallet and the details of the owner.

Summary

Deal with lost and found items

When dealing with lost and found items:

- Ensure all items received as found items are safe and legal
- Be alert to ensuring no found items are 'suspicious'
- Involve management/the authorities where a suspicious item is identified
- Treat all items received as found items with proper care, attention and respect
- Store all found items to protect them from damage and theft
- Store items in such a way that facilitates their identification and retrieval
- Record comprehensive and accurate details of all lost and found items in the lost and found register
- Use appropriate interpersonal and communication skills when dealing with customers/guests
- Attach a lost and found tag/slip to all found items and cross-reference the item against a number in the lost and found register and the same number of the tag/slip
- Investigate/take action to determine the owner of found items
- Contact owner when a found item of theirs is identified, subject to the need to be tactful in relation to returning lost items of a 'sensitive' nature
- Advise internal venue staff regarding found items to make them aware and assist in identifying owner/s.

Element 3: Deal with claims for lost items

3.1 Assist claimant to identify lost property

Introduction

When a person makes a claim for a found item it is important to provide high levels of service to assist this person.

This Section identifies the activities involved in helping the claimant identify their lost property.

Receiving a claim for lost property

People who have lost items will commonly contact the venue to determine if the item has been found:

- In person – walking into the venue to make an enquiry
- By telephone – calling the venue to see if their item has been handed in
- Via email – writing to ask if a nominated item has been found.



These notes detail the established procedures for dealing with a person who arrives in person seeking claim an item they have lost at your property.

Activities to assist claimant identify lost property

The basic requirements when a person arrives in person to claim an item they have lost and which has been found are:

Use appropriate interpersonal skills

This means delivering lost and found services with the same care, courtesy and professionalism as all other services delivered by the venue.

Greet and welcome the person as you would a paying customer/guest.

Never:

- Give the person the impression providing lost and found services is a chore or an interruption to other workplace activities
- Give the person impression you are doing the claimant them a favour by helping them get back their lost property
- Treat the person as if they were trying to do something illegal – you have to check they are not attempting to claim something that is not theirs but never adopt the attitude of interrogating/questioning a claimant as if they were a criminal.

Identify lost item

This is the first step when determining whether or not the person you are dealing with has a legitimate claim on the item they are seeking to obtain – you need to ask the person to answer some basic questions to identify the item they are seeking to claim:



- What is the item? Ask them to provide a brief yet detailed description of the item – if the item is a bag, suitcase or similar you should also ask them to describe the contents
- Where was the item lost? Ask them to tell you where they lost the item or where they believe they last had possession of the article
- When did they lose the item or become aware they had lost the item? Ask them for the day, date, and time
- What is the value of the item? Ask them how much the item is worth: this is only a legitimate question when the value of the item was recorded when the item was reported as lost
- Who are they? Ask them their name and for proof of identity (see Section 3.2 and 3.3)
- Was the item reported as lost?

You must compare the answers given by the claimant to the information contained in the Lost and Found Register to:

- Identify the item being claimed – see below
- Determine if their answers are correct
- Determine if the person making the claim is attempting to make a false claim.

Identify item in the Register

When the person has provided a description of the item, you should next attempt to locate the item in the Lost and Found Register.

Identifying and returning a reported Lost item

Where the claimant is seeking to claim an item that was reported as lost you should turn to the Lost items section of the Lost and Found Register to identify if a report was made about the item.

Does the information provided by the claimant align with what is recorded?

If the information provided matches what is in the Register, you can proceed.

Where answers are different to the information contained in the Lost and Found Register, you should involve management and advise them of your concerns.

Identifying and returning a Found item

Where the claimant is seeking to claim an item that was not reported as lost you should turn to the Found items section of the Lost and Found Register and look for an item matching the details provided by the person.

Again, if the information provided matches what is in the Register, you can proceed – if not, involve management/your Supervisor.

Obtain the item

Using the information in the Register and the sequential number listed against the item:

- Explain to the claimant you have located the item in the Register and will now go and obtain it
- Excuse yourself and go to the Lost and Found storage
- Locate the items using the number of the item as listed in the Register to find the Lost and Found Tag/Slip
- Verify the item actually matches the item described/being sought
- Return to the claimant and:
 - Allow the claimant to view the item
 - Ask the claimant to verify it is theirs – or not
 - Ask the claimant to describe the contents – where applicable.

Most claimants are honest about claiming an item – if an item presented to them is not theirs they will (in the vast majority of cases) state it is not the correct item but you should be alert to visual cues indicating the item presented to them is not theirs.

Need to modify these procedures

These procedures will need to be modified where the person telephones the venue or sends an email.

For example when a person telephones the venue or sends an email regarding a lost item you may deal with them over the telephone/email to:

- Establish and confirm/verify their identity – and address/contact details
- Secure information regarding the description and value of an item, when and where it was lost and whether or not it was reported as lost/stolen
- Arrange for them to call in to the venue to view the item (if the item has been found) and complete the claim process
- Arrange for another person to identify and collect the item on their behalf
- Determine the method of return of the item to the person who may live a long way away or in an overseas country.

The point being not all lost property claimants can be dealt with on a face-to-face basis – many items will need to be processed using another means to prove ownership and arrange return.

3.2 Verify ownership of property claimed

Introduction

It is vital found items are only returned to their legitimate owner, or a person authorised to collect the item on behalf of the rightful owner.

This Section details techniques for verifying the ownership of property being claimed.

Points to remember

When verifying ownership of an item it can be useful to bear in mind:

- Keep up the excellent standards of service levels – maintain positive and appropriate interpersonal skills. Be nice to people – ask them questions as opposed to interrogating them
- Let claimants know why you are doing what you are doing – explain it is company policy for you to have to ask questions to determine ownership so the item can only be claimed by its true owner. Make them aware you are doing what you are doing for *their* benefit
- Not everyone will have 100% recall – people often forget aspects about their own items even though they use/see these items every day: not being able to describe what you believe to be an important or obvious detail does not necessarily mean the person is *not* the rightful owner
- Most people are unable to provide undeniable proof of ownership – most people will not have, for example, a receipt for the item or some other legal document showing they have title for the item: this means you will have to use other means to determine whether or not they are the owner
- Many found items are claimed on behalf of the owner by a person authorised to do so by the legitimate owner – this means you will need to verify their identification.



Ways to verify ownership

When you are satisfied you have obtained the item claimed by the claimant as being lost, and the claimant has identified it as the missing item you must next ensure the claimant is legitimately entitled to the item.

Obtaining an accurate description of the item

This can be done by asking questions such as:

- 'How much money is in the wallet?'
- 'What make is the watch?'
- 'What brand/make is the computer?'

It can also be achieved by the owner:

- Providing extra information – such as 'There is a scratch on the inside of the case, about six cm long, near the top of the case', or 'There is a red ink stain inside the front cover'
- Showing a photograph of them with the item.



Matching photographs

Where the item being claimed contains photographic evidence of the claimant, this should be used as a way of determining the legitimacy of the claimant.

For example:

- Check wallets and bags for photographic identification of the owner
- Where the item contains a passport or photo ID driver's licence (or similar), use these as a means of proving the identity of the claimant.

When checking photographs:

- Use common sense – photographs are not always good portrayals of the individual; photographs may have been taken some time ago and the person may have changed their look (by changing hair style/colour)
- Use the same attention to detail as you would when checking identification for other purposes – such as service of alcohol; entry to the premises.

Sighting ownership documents

As mentioned it is relatively rare for people to be able to provide ownership documents for items they are claiming but it does sometimes occur (such as when claiming items they have recently purchased duty free, or at a local store/business).

Sighting or checking ownership documents may mean visually seeing:

- Title for the goods
- Receipts
- A credit/debit card transaction document.

3.3 Obtain identification from owner

Introduction



When the correct item has been obtained and the claimant has confirmed it is theirs to your satisfaction, the next step is to obtain proof as to who the claimant is.

This step is a relatively brief one but very important in ensuring the item is only released to its rightful owner.

This Section identifies the ways you can capture evidence as to who the owner is.

Why bother with this?

You must always obtain proof of who the item is released to:

- Prove the item was correctly released to the right person – if evidence of this is ever required
- Provide a starting point for enquiry if the item is released to the wrong person and the rightful owner subsequently makes a claim for the item
- Comply with internal policies and procedures relating to returning items to owners.

Owner identification

Where the claimant is the owner of the item the most common identification to obtain from the person is:

- Driver's licence
- Passport.



However, while the majority of people will have at least one form of this identification, not *all* people will.

Where people do not have these forms of ID you could/should:

- Ask for some other form of photographic identification – this may be a government issued ID, a workplace-based form or a community-based membership card
- Involve other staff/management who know the claimant – and who can vouch for who they are
- Ask them to sign a form – and compare this to the Registration Form they completed on arrival at the venue (where applicable).

Capture evidence

When you have been presented with suitable identification from the owner:

- Check it to ensure it is legitimate and has not been tampered with – or has had important aspects altered
- Copy/photocopy it – for filing in the Lost and Found Register/filing system.

It is ***not acceptable*** to simply sight suitable identification without capturing proof of it.

If it is not possible to obtain a photocopy of the identification you should:

- Detail the type/nature of the identification – such as (for example) 'Work ID XYZ organisation', 'XYZ Membership card'
- Capture relevant ID details – such as:
 - Name the ID was issued in
 - Any addresses for the organisation and/or claimant
 - Any applicable dates – 'Valid till xx/xx/xx'.

Check the copy

It must be standard procedure to check any copy made of IDs against the original to ensure:

- All necessary information has been captured
- All details are legible.

Sometimes it may be necessary to make a second copy to ensure all necessary details are suitably obtained for future reference.

Authorised collection of an item

'Owner identification' also includes identification of anyone authorised by the owner to act as their agent to make a claim on their behalf.

In these cases, obtaining identification may involve:

- Obtaining hard-copy proof (an email, or letter) from the owner authorising the agent/other person to claim the item
- Obtaining copy of request from the venue to the owner asking the claimant to furnish identification
- Obtaining personal identification of the third-party claimant/agent – such as passport or driver's licence as proof of identity.

The above evidence should also be copied and filed in the Lost and Found Register/filing system.

3.4 Complete lost and found register

Introduction

The Lost and Found Register is the central document for lost and found items and must be referred to and updated whenever a claim is made for lost property.

The Lost and Found Register must even be updated where a claim for an item is made, but is refused.

This Section identifies the details of the Lost and Found Register to be completed when a lost item is returned to its owner.

Completing the Lost and Found Register

Completion of the Lost and Found Register must reflect the requirements/columns in the Register – some Registers will require more information/updating than others.

Returning an item

When returning an item to a claimant you may need to:

- Complete details of claimant – name and contact details
- Insert identification of article/s used to identify claimant – passport, driver's licence including relevant details (number of item, expiry date) or copy of same
- Insert identification of article/s used as claimant's proof of ownership of the item – photograph, receipt
- Obtain a signature from the claimant – verifying they have received the item released to them.



Refusing an item

When you determine an item should not be returned to a claimant you should:

- Involve management
- Explain your reasons to management

- Allow management to assess the situation – they may decide to give the item to the claimant
- Politely explain to the claimant why the refusal is being made – highlighting this action is being taken to safeguard property of the rightful owner
- Advise about what extra proof the claimant needs to provide – to enable you to release the item to them
- Apologise for the inconvenience
- Make an entry in the register reflecting what the claimant has been told – a separate piece of paper may need to be added to the Register
- Sign/initial the Register – and management should also sign/initial the Register as proof of their involvement.

3.5 Assist claimants who contact the establishment from another country, or distant area, to claim lost items

Introduction

Where people contact the venue from another country (or a distant location) you are expected to assist them claim lost items.

The same care, attention and professionalism must be paid to these claimants as is paid to face-to-face claimants.

This Section describes what may need to be done to address this relatively common situation.

Activities in assisting remote people to claim a lost item

Guests/customers may contact the venue to claim a lost item:

- In response to contact made with them by the venue – mentioning a found item
- Following up on a report made – when they reported a lost item while they were at the venue
- On chance – this is arguably the most common type of contact and occurs when the individual discovers they have lost an item and contacts the venue hoping it has been found/handed in. In reality, they often really do not know where or when they lost the item.

Communication options

Guests/customers who contact the venue from a remote location or distant place may do so by telephone, fax or email.

It is difficult to communicate with and assist people using faxes and email – talking to them on the telephone is the preferred option as this enables questions to be asked and answered, follow-up information to be discussed and/or sought as the need arises, and enables a fast response to the query.

The second-most preferred option is the use of email but this usually results in a drawn out settlement of the query: email does however enable sending of photographs and copies of documents and some properties may be web-cam enabled.

What is involved?

When talking to a person from another country/distant area regarding their claim for a lost item, all the checks and verifications mentioned earlier in these notes must be undertaken.

The fact you are not dealing with the claimant face-to-face does not allow you to apply a lesser standard of proof, ownership or identity.

The factors to be addressed include:

- Determining legitimate ownership of the items claimed – this may be achieved by a combination of:
 - Asking the claimant to forward required, acceptable, or identified evidence
 - Researching internal documents/records – such as Guest History, and/or Rooming List
 - Obtaining detailed description of items, when and where they were lost and value – to the best extent possible
- Identifying the exact item – to guard against a similar, but incorrect item, being forwarded
- Determining guest's preferred method of having the item returned – this will often depend on the nature of the item (such as whether it is big/heavy or small/light and taking into account how expensive it is, and the sentimental nature of the article. Options include:
 - Mail – with further options relating to insurance, priority delivery and/or express post
 - Courier
 - Air

Other options may exist (for example, return by sea/boat; private vehicle) but these are not commonly used or offered as alternatives

- Advising claimant the venue will process the return but will require payment for expenses entailed in return of the item – these expenses are usually limited to direct expenses (packaging, wrapping, insurance, fees and charges) but do not normally include a component for 'time and trouble' taken to return the item.

Where known the venue will inform the claimant of the estimated cost to return the item but (because no charge is levied for 'time and trouble') it is not common practice to obtain quotations for remitting the item and forwarding these quotes to the claimant.

- Obtaining relevant contact details of the claimant for delivery of the item – a check may be made to ensure these details are the same as the claimant's details already recorded in the internal Guest History: this is a one way of ensuring items are sent to their rightful owners
- Informing claimant regarding date/time the item will be dispatched – so claimant can have an idea of when to expect the item.

Processing return of the item



When arrangements for the return of an item have been finalised you must process the return of items in accordance with agreed arrangements.

It is important to work quickly but to ensure, at the same time, the item being returned is not damaged.

Processing may involve:

- Wrapping and packaging the item – to protect it during transit
- Addressing the item/package
- Selecting and paying for appropriate/agreed insurance and/or other delivery-related services
- Notifying a carrier/courier to collect the item
- Taking the item to a carrier/courier or delivery service
- Capturing consignment details, number, expected delivery date/time and/or delivery route – including details of any online tracking service offered by the carrier
- Paying for the return of the item – and obtaining receipt
- Notifying claimant the item has been sent – and providing relevant tracking details and/or delivery information.

Updating the Lost and Found Register

When the item has been processed for return, the Lost and Found Register should be updated.

Details may need to be included, as appropriate, to identify:

- Delivery address for the item
- Name of carrier or service used to deliver/return the item
- Details of any special service – such as express post, insurance, door-to-door delivery
- Cost
- Date and time sent
- Details of any item/delivery-specific data – such as consignment number, delivery receipt number.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

- 3.1 Submit written and/or other evidence (such as video or photographs) to demonstrate/prove you have dealt effectively with a real-life or simulated claim for a lost item, and:
- Assisted claimant to identify their lost property/item
 - Verified ownership of the item claimed
 - Obtained suitable identification from the claimant
 - Completed/updated the Lost and Found register to reflect return of the item to the owner.
- 3.2. For your workplace – or a nominated alternative venue – prepare and present a submission:
- Identifying the types of charges involved when the venue returns a found item to an overseas and/or international guest/customer
 - Listing the options for returning small-size 'found' items – such as an item of jewellery, a wallet or a passport
 - Listing the options for returning large-size 'found' items – such as laptop computer, briefcase or suitcase
 - Explaining how the venue obtains necessary proof of ownership from an overseas or international guest/customer before returning found items to them

Summary

Deal with claims for lost items

When dealing with claims for lost items:

- Provide courteous and professional levels and standards of service
- Ensure the correct item is identified by the claimant – obtain details of the item
- Check the Lost and Found Register to identify if the item is recorded
- Retrieve identified item from storage and confirm it is the correct item
- Obtain proof of ownership from claimant
- Obtain proof of identity of claimant
- Record claimant details and update Lost and Found Register
- Involve management and/or refuse to release any items where there is doubt about the legitimacy of a claim
- Be prepared to assist out-of-country or remote people recover lost items by applying and adapting face-to-face protocols – always recover cost of remitting these items
- Follow up out-of-country or remote area claims by processing the return of legitimate claims and advising the claimant of action taken.

Element 4: Deal with unclaimed items

4.1 Comply with establishment policies

Introduction

When dealing with unclaimed lost and found items it is vital establishment policies are followed.

These policies will comply with legal requirements and demonstrate adherence to appropriate business ethics.

This Section identifies standard industry policies regarding the disposal of items.



Holding times

This policy will specify the length of time a property will retain an item before disposing of it.

The length of time items are held usually depends on the classification of the item.

Valuable items

Valuable items are held for between six – twelve months.

Valuable items are held longer because there is a greater chance the owner will eventually make a claim for them.

Non-valuable items

Non-valuable items are commonly held for three – six months.

If the establishment has a guest library, unclaimed *books* may be entered into the library.

Perishable food

Where perishable food is held, it is usually kept for 24 – 48 hours only.

Many venues immediately throw out all open bottles of drink, and all opened food found in a departed guest room/refrigerator.

Disposal of items

This policy dictates what happens to found items if they are not claimed.

Valuable items

Unclaimed valuable are treated differently to other items because of their importance and/or value.

After their designated holding period has elapsed, valuable items may be:

- Handed in to Police – this is the recommended procedure and ensures no complications or subsequent legal action
- Given to charity – this option demonstrates corporate citizenship on behalf of the venue and enables the property to prove staff did not benefit from someone else's loss
- Returned to the person who found them – this is not recommended for items where personal details of the owner are present



Returning items to the finder may be policy only for valuable items of 'lesser value'.

Note: Police often retain an item that is handed in for a certain period (say, 6 months) and then return it to the person/organisation who handed it in. The item may then be given to the finder.

Non-valuable items

Policy regarding disposal of non-valuable items following expiry of their holding time may be:

- Finder may be offered the item – this means the staff member who finds the item may be given the option of keeping the item
- Where the finder of a non-valuable item is a member of the public or a guest, the item is usually thrown out – the time and trouble involved in contacting the guest is not worth the effort unless a specific promise to do so was made at the time the item was handed in and recorded in the lost and Found Register
- The item is thrown out into the trash – some properties have a SOP all non-valuable items must be thrown out: nothing can be offered/given to staff. This avoids potential problems relating to the venue failing to discharge its Duty of Care.

Perishable items

Some properties have a SOP **all** perishable items must be thrown out – nothing can be given to staff, regardless of whether it is in an open or un-opened package.

Disposal of perishable items may include:

- Open/partially used perishable items are thrown out – staff are not allowed to consume open/partially used items
- Venues often require this in order for them to discharge their Duty of care for their staff – this policy potentially protects staff from eating or drinking poisoned or otherwise contaminated food/drink
- Unopened perishable items may be given to staff – this generally applies only to items in a sealed container (such as a bottle, can or packet) where the seal/package has not been compromised
- Unopened perishable items may be thrown out – many properties have this as a standard requirement to protect staff. (see Duty of Care obligations [above])

4.2 Comply with legal obligations

Introduction

It is imperative all legal requirements are complied with when disposing of found items.

This is essential to protect the venue and individual staff against criminal prosecution and/or civil action.

This Section describes the legal issues to be aware of in this respect.



Bailment

Bailment is the legal position where the ownership of goods is transferred from one person to another when an item is handed in to the venue as a found item.

Venues are under an obligation to:

- Look after/protect the item – to retain/maintain it in the original condition it was in when it was found
- Return the item on demand – when claimed by the rightful owner.

See Section 1.4 for fuller details.

Theft by finding

It is possible staff – or members of the public, guests or customers – who take items found in the venue for their own use, could be guilty of an offence called 'Theft by finding'.

'Theft' involves deliberate intent to permanently deprive the rightful owner of their legal right to their goods.

Note: Check with your Supervisor or local authorities to determine more specifically the 'theft by finding' laws as they apply to your country.

Abandonment

Items can only be taken for personal/private use if they have been 'abandoned' – that is, if they have been deliberately left with the intention by the owner of relinquishing legal title (or ownership) to the goods.

'Losing' an item accidentally does not fall under the definition of abandonment.

To avoid a charge of 'theft by finding' the finder is required to take reasonable action to determine/identify and locate the finder. If an item has been handed in to the Lost and Found facility at a venue and the venue has tried to identify/contact the owner, then this requirement may have been fulfilled.

Mislaid property

Property cannot be seen to be 'abandoned' if it is simply mislaid/misplaced.

This relates to items placed somewhere by the owner who then forgets to pick the item again when they leave. For example, a guest may leave their handbag/wallet at a POS register or at Reception when paying an account or checking out and forget to pick it up when they depart.

This item is deemed to be neither lost nor abandoned but 'mislaid'.

Such items must be regarded, for the purposes of the venue/this unit as 'lost' and handed in to the Lost and Found facility.

Ramifications

It is possible the person who takes a found item (that is, an item which is either lost or mislaid) as their own may be:

- Charged by the Police with a crime (theft by finding)
- Sued by the rightful owner of the item – so as to be reimbursed for the value of the item involved.

In addition, the employer may elect to terminate your employment.

The lesson in all this

To avoid potential legal and employment-related problems, you must always hand in anything you find.

At work, hand things in to the Lost and Found facility or your Supervisor.

Outside work, hand items in to the Police.

4.3 Remove items from storage and complete lost and found register to record movement and disposal of items

Introduction

Whenever an item stored in the Lost and Found facility is returned to its owner or otherwise disposed of, the Lost and Found Register must be completed to record the action taken.

This Section details the entries to be made in the Lost and Found Register to record disposal of an unclaimed item.

Frequency of action

The Lost and Found Register should be checked every month (according to internal policy) to determine which items have reached their designated holding time.

Checking items daily is not required, and checking on a weekly basis is not common.

All items reaching/exceeding their designated storage or holding time should be removed from storage and disposed of according to house/establishment policies.

Activities involved

Activities involved in removing and disposing of items from the Lost and Found facility that have reached their designated holding time include:



- Take the Lost and Found Register to the storage area/facility – if it is not already located in that area
- Read the Register to identify items exceeding their holding times – use the 'Date' column as the reference point coupled with knowledge of venue holding times
- Obtain the Lost and Found Tag number for the item – reading it from the Register and ensuring the correct item is being selected: always double-check the item chosen really is the one to be actioned
- Locate the item in the Lost and Found facility – and remove it
- The item may be placed directly into a trash container (where it is to be disposed of) or into a cart where it is to be forwarded to the Police, a charity or a person
- Tidy/re-arrange the Lost and Found facility, shelves or other locations – to reflect the items removed and make room for future items
- Update the Lost and Found Register – this may require (depending on venue requirements and/or columns in the Register):
 - Enter the date
 - Enter how the item was disposed of – or where it was sent to
 - Signature or initial of person performing the task

Note: some properties require a line to be drawn through all items disposed of to make it easier to identify the items no longer in storage.

- Deal with the item as appropriate:
 - Throw items to be disposed of into the trash
 - Give items to designated people, as identified
 - Hand in items to the Police
 - Deliver items to the charity
- Obtain receipts for items – where appropriate:
 - Police will provide a receipt for all items handed in
 - Many charities will provide some written record of donations
- Insert receipts and other appropriate written records into Lost and Found Register (or other appropriate filing system) – as proof of correct disposal
- Remember it is not enough to do the right thing, you must be able to *prove* you did the right thing
- Return the Lost and Found Register to its original location (where applicable) – so it can be used by others when needed.

Work Projects

It is a requirement of this Unit you complete Work Projects as advised by your Trainer. You must submit documentation, suitable evidence or other relevant proof of completion of the project to your Trainer by the agreed date.

4.1 For the venue where you work – or a nominated alternative venue – prepare and present three (3) Checklists, Posters or procedures (one for each topic) that could be used by staff to assist them:

- Comply with establishment Lost and Found policies
 - Comply with legislated Lost and Found requirements
 - Remove found items from storage at the end of the designated holding time, and complete the Lost and Found Register to record the disposal of items (that is, items are handed to police, charities or finder, or are thrown out – as opposed to items returned to their owner).
-

Summary

Deal with unclaimed items

When dealing with unclaimed items:

- Ensure establishment policies are complied with relating to the disposal of valuable, non-valuable and perishable items
- Valuable items are commonly handed into Police or donated to charity
- Most properties will not allow staff to consume open or partially used food or drinks
- Ensure Duty of Care obligations are discharged
- Make sure all found items are returned to owners in fulfilment of bailment requirements
- Be aware of the law regarding 'theft by finding' and take care not to breach these requirements
- Check the holding times/dates for found items every week/month according to house policy
- Remove all items in accordance with establishment policy when designated holding times have been reached/exceeded
- Update the Lost and Found Register to reflect clearance/disposal of items from the Lost and Found facility
- Obtain and file receipts for items given to the Police and charities
- Ensure you can prove the action you took in regard to disposal of items from the Lost and Found facility.

Presentation of written work

1. Introduction

It is important for students to present carefully prepared written work. Written presentation in industry must be professional in appearance and accurate in content. If students develop good writing skills whilst studying, they are able to easily transfer those skills to the workplace.

2. Style



Students should write in a style that is simple and concise. Short sentences and paragraphs are easier to read and understand. It helps to write a plan and at least one draft of the written work so that the final product will be well organized. The points presented will then follow a logical sequence and be relevant. Students should frequently refer to the question asked, to keep 'on track'. Teachers recognize and are critical of work that does not answer the question, or is 'padded' with irrelevant material. In summary, remember to:

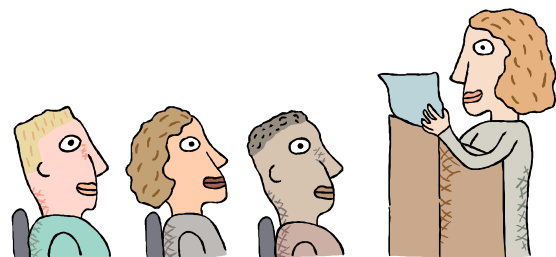
- Plan ahead
- Be clear and concise
- Answer the question
- Proofread the final draft.

3. Presenting Written Work

Types of written work

Students may be asked to write:

- Short and long reports
- Essays
- Records of interviews
- Questionnaires
- Business letters
- Resumes.



Format

All written work should be presented on A4 paper, single-sided with a left-hand margin. If work is word-processed, one-and-a-half or double spacing should be used. Handwritten work must be legible and should also be well spaced to allow for ease of reading. New paragraphs should not be indented but should be separated by a space. Pages must be numbered. If headings are also to be numbered, students should use a logical and sequential system of numbering.

Cover Sheet

All written work should be submitted with a cover sheet stapled to the front that contains:

- The student's name and student number
- The name of the class/unit
- The due date of the work
- The title of the work
- The teacher's name
- A signed declaration that the work does not involve plagiarism.

Keeping a Copy

Students must keep a copy of the written work in case it is lost. This rarely happens but it can be disastrous if a copy has not been kept.

Inclusive language

This means language that includes every section of the population. For instance, if a student were to write 'A nurse is responsible for the patients in her care at all times' it would be implying that all nurses are female and would be excluding male nurses.

Examples of appropriate language are shown on the right:

Mankind	<i>Humankind</i>
Barman/maid	<i>Bar attendant</i>
Host/hostess	<i>Host</i>
Waiter/waitress	<i>Waiter or waiting staff</i>

Recommended reading

Hayes, D.K., 2007 (2nd ed'n), *Hotel operations management*, Pearson/Prentice Hall. Upper Saddle River, N.J.

Hickman, A., 2010, *Provide lost and found facility: SITXCCS305A*, William Angliss Institute, Melbourne, Australia

Trainee evaluation sheet

Provide a Lost and Found Facility

The following statements are about the competency you have just completed.

Please tick the appropriate box	Agree	Don't Know	Do Not Agree	Does Not Apply
There was too much in this competency to cover without rushing.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most of the competency seemed relevant to me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency was at the right level for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I got enough help from my trainer.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The amount of activities was sufficient.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The competency allowed me to use my own initiative.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My training was well-organized.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer had time to answer my questions.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I understood how I was going to be assessed.	☐	☐	☐	☐
I was given enough time to practice.	☐	☐	☐	☐
My trainer feedback was useful.	☐	☐	☐	☐
Enough equipment was available and it worked well.	☐	☐	☐	☐
The activities were too hard for me.	☐	☐	☐	☐

The best things about this unit were:

The worst things about this unit were:

The things you should change in this unit are:



Trainee self-assessment checklist

As an indicator to your Trainer/Assessor of your readiness for assessment in this unit please complete the following and hand to your Trainer/Assessor.

Provide a Lost and Found Facility

		Yes	No*
Element 1: Establish lost and found facility			
1.1	Name properties that may have a lost and found facility	☐	☐
1.2	Identify appropriate location for lost and found facility	☐	☐
1.3	Develop in-house lost and found policies and procedures	☐	☐
1.4	Identify the legal requirements that apply to lost and found items	☐	☐
1.5	Communicate the location and function of the lost and found facility to guests and staff	☐	☐
1.6	Establish lost and found register	☐	☐
Element 2: Deal with lost and found items			
2.1	Check items for safety and legality and take appropriate action	☐	☐
2.2	Record found items in lost and found register	☐	☐
2.3	Record items reported lost in lost and found register	☐	☐
2.4	Tag the found item	☐	☐
2.5	Store the found item appropriately	☐	☐
2.6	Notify owner, if known	☐	☐
2.7	Notify internal establishment staff to facilitate return of found item to owner	☐	☐
Element 3: Deal with claims for lost items			
3.1	Assist claimant to identify lost property	☐	☐
3.2	Verify ownership of property claimed	☐	☐
3.3	Obtain identification from owner	☐	☐
3.4	Complete lost and found register	☐	☐
3.5	Assist claimants who contact the establishment from another country, or distant area, to claim lost items	☐	☐

		Yes	No*
Element 4: Deal with unclaimed items			
4.1	Comply with establishment policies	☐	☐
4.2	Comply with legal obligations	☐	☐
4.3	Remove items from storage and complete lost and found register to record movement and disposal of items	☐	☐

Statement by Trainee:

I believe I am ready to be assessed on the following as indicated above:

Signed: _____

Date: _____

Note:

For all boxes where a **No*** is ticked, please provide details of the extra steps or work you need to do to become ready for assessment.

